**Assignment Report**

Assignment 2: Personas

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**Abstract**

This report develops one design persona for our group project (Group 05, visiting students at USI). It describes the system, the range of user characteristics found in our interviews, and the process that led from three candidate personas to one primary persona, Maja. The project is at the end of the data-gathering stage and the persona is a first version based on seven transcribed interviews (I1–I7).

## 1. The System

**System:** our group designs for visiting (exchange) students at USI in Lugano. It is a mobile companion for the first weeks of a stay. The task is not final yet; our interview script covers four options: digitalising administration (permit, Punto Città, health-insurance exemption), housing, a USI schedule/map app, and a shopping helper. The persona therefore targets needs that all four share.

**Data:** seven interviews, numbered I1 to I7 (I = interview; students from Italy, Finland, Italy, Russia, Germany, Italy, Mexico), followed our semi-structured script of 40 questions (arrival, housing, administration, campus, courses, daily life). They were recorded and transcribed.

## 2. Range of User Characteristics

Table 1 lists the characteristics that differ between the students we interviewed and that matter for the system. Language stands out: most problems in the data are larger for a student who reads no Italian.

| Characteristic | Range in our data | Source |
|---|---|---|
| Language | Native Italian; no Italian (needs English); understands some Italian but reads little; French only | I1, I3, I6; I2, I5; I7; I4 |
| Length of stay | Exchange semester of about five months; one-year double degree; full degree | I2, I5, I7; I3; I4 |
| Experience | First university exchange; or an earlier exchange (Austria, Florence) | I1–I3, I6; I5, I7 |
| Administration | EU: permit L, Punto Città, insurance exemption, partly in Italian; non-EU: visa and permit took five to six months (I7); several offices, paper and post (I5) | I1–I7 |
| Housing route | USI Home granted (I2, I5, I7) or full even after an early application (I1, I6); USI housing website; ESN WhatsApp group; agency with many documents (I3) | I1–I7 |
| Digital habits | Phone first; WhatsApp, Google Translate, ChatGPT; one-stop university app at home (I1, I3); printer set-up is hard (I6) | I1–I4, I6 |
| Social life | ESN events attended and liked (I3, I7) or overwhelming and full of spam (I2, I4); announcements in Italian get skipped (I2) | I2–I4, I7 |

*Table 1. Characteristics of the interviewed students (I4 is a full-degree student, so context only).*

Table 1 shows that students differ less in what they must do than in how well they can read it and how much help they get: the same steps were easy for Italian speakers and for the student guided by the USI international office (I5), but not for the one who did not know what to expect (I2).

## 3. Design Persona and Process

### 3.1 Process

**Steps:** I followed section 9.4 of the book and the lecture. First, I read the seven transcripts and marked every note about a person's goals, habits and problems. Second, I grouped these notes by the characteristics in Table 1 and wrote three candidate personas (Table 2). Third, I winnowed them with four questions: is it a visiting student; do its needs recur in several interviews; is it an edge case; does it add something the others do not? Fourth, I picked one primary persona. The book says the design should be just right for the chosen persona and suffice for the others, so I chose the candidate whose needs contain those of the rest.

| Candidate | Main needs (source) | Decision |
|---|---|---|
| A. Italian-speaking exchange student | USI Home full even after an early application (I1, I6); one timetable that matches the room monitor (I1); one app for university tasks (I1, I3); printer set-up (I6). | Needs are a subset of B. Kept as secondary. |
| B. Exchange student with no Italian | Letters, forms and events in Italian (I2); parking website only in Italian (I5); no confirmation after applying (I2); several offices (I5); labels in shops (I2, I3, I4); same housing and timetable problems as A. | **Selected** as primary persona. |
| C. Non-EU exchange student | Visa and permit took five to six months, permit appointment still ahead (I7); reads little Italian (I7). | Kept as secondary: one interview, and the visa steps come on top of B's needs. |

*Table 2. Candidate personas and the selection decision.*

### 3.2 The Persona: Maja Nowak

Figure 1 shows Maja. She is invented, a mix of what I2, I5 and the other interviews told us, and not an average of the students. Her goals, frustrations and behaviour come from interview notes (tags I1–I7); her name, age and home town are invented.



**Maja Nowak**
22, from Kraków, Poland
Master's student, business informatics
One-semester exchange, first time abroad
English C1; no Italian or German
Permit L; shared flat found on the USI housing site

**Goals.** Finish every arrival task correctly and know it went through. Know which room and time for each class. Meet other exchange students in small groups. Get food and daily things without Italian (I2, I4, I5).

**Frustrations.** Letters and emails arrive in Italian and she cannot tell if she should have received them (I2). She waited months after applying for housing with no confirmation (I2). Website and room monitor showed different rooms (I1). Her course page was not visible three weeks after her request (I2). Shops close at about 7 pm (I2, I3) and labels are in German or Italian (I2, I3, I4). Admin is spread over several offices, with paper and post (I5). Events are crowded and announced in Italian (I2); the ESN chat is full of spam (I4).

**Behaviour.** Phone first. Checks products with Google Translate (I2). Takes a friend who speaks Italian or German to the shop (I2, I4). Hears about events from friends and does not go alone (I2). Expects admin to be online (I2, I5). Leans on one helper: the USI international office session and its English forms (I5).

*"I don't actually know if it went through."* (I2)

*Figure 1. Primary design persona. The avatar is an illustration, not a photo of a real person; I1–I7 are the interview numbers.*

### 3.3 Why Maja, and Limits

**Why Maja:** the Italian barrier makes every other problem worse. A design that works for her (English information, one place for all steps, a confirmation after each step, one place for room and time) should also work for Candidate A and mostly for C. I5 shows that guidance from the USI international office removes much of the problem, so Maja stands for the moments without such help. I used only the interview notes, not my own experience, to avoid designing for myself. **Limits:** seven interviews, six with visiting students, three of them with no Italian. Maja is a first version to confirm with more interviews.